

CONTEXTS OF SEXUALITY

CULTURE, HISTORY, AND RELIGION

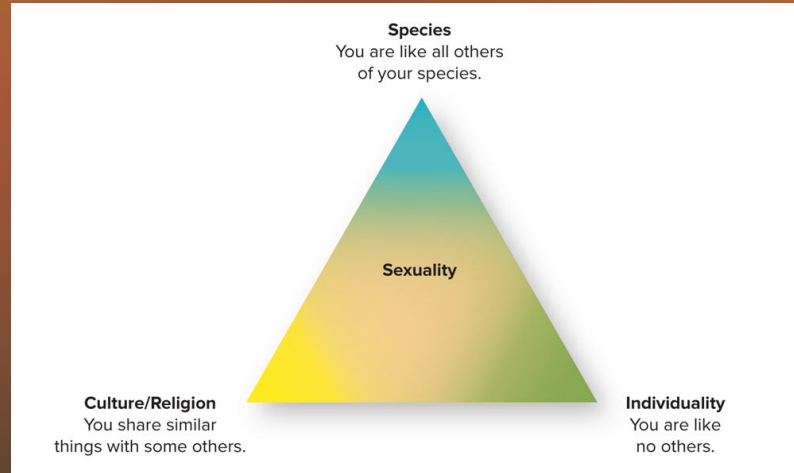
Ms. Mitchell

The Sexual Triangle: Species, Culture, and Individual

Human sexual experience

- Humans developed
 - Rules and beliefs about sex that are cultural, Individual, and religious
 - Emotional bonding in sexual relationships
- Humans and bonobo chimpanzee — only species to pursue sex for fun, pleasure, and procreation
- **Procreation** — conception of offspring.

Figure 2.1 The sexual triangle



Each element of the sexual triangle contributes to human sexuality. The three elements intersect with each other as a result of millions of years of evolution of our species, hundreds of generations of the development of culture, and the uniqueness of each individual.

**Where did you learn about sex?
Who had THE talk with you?
How old were you?
What was discussed?**

Human Sexual Nature as Expressed Through Culture

Norms — cultural rules about acceptable behavior.

Human sexual nature — combination of human culture and human nature to produce sexual behavior.

Human Sexual Nature as Expressed Through Culture

Human sexuality enhanced **pair bonding** — the sexual and romantic association between two people.

- Pair bonding provided great adaptive advantages.
 - Protection
 - Reproduction
 - Sharing of resources

Culture reduced feelings of sexual competition.

- Norms around sex and marriage prevented male conflicts over females.

Human Sexual Nature as Expressed Through Culture

Characteristics shaped by culture that express human sexual nature

- Sex for reproduction, pair bonding, and pleasure;
- Slow development of sexual maturity;
- Nuclear families (parents and children) and multigenerational extended families;
- Sex forbidden within family units (incest);
- Societal influence that reinforces group norms, membership, and sexual regulation.

Activity: History of Sexuality

In groups of 3-4, guess the dates of the following events and put them in chronological order

1. When was the first birth control pill provided?
2. When was the term 'homosexuality' coined?
3. When was the Comstock law (made contraceptives illegal)?
4. When was the first issue of Playboy printed?
5. When was Roe vs. Wade passed?
6. Homosexuality removed from the DSMV

35,000 BCE

First cave paintings and statues representing human sexuality/ritual/human individuality



3150 BCE

Ancient Egyptian civilization and divine kingship/incest marriage

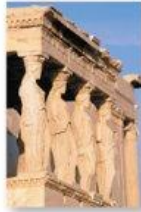
5000 BCE



5000 BCE

Rise of Hinduism and positive approach to sexuality

1000 BCE

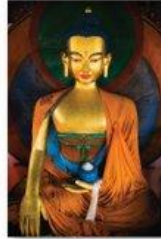


800 BCE

Ancient Greek sexuality and religion depicting same-sex relationships and sexual anatomy

500 BCE

Rise of Buddhism and new ideas about sexual being



500 CE

500-1500

Rise of Roman Catholic Church

1200

1200-1834

Holy Inquisition trials for witchcraft, sodomy, and adultery

1500

1600

Age of Enlightenment, science opens way for new medical ideas about sex



1500s

Protestant Reformation divides Roman Catholic Church

1837-1901

Victorian era
and invention of
modern sexuality

1800s

Rise of public
health system
and sexology
in Europe and
United States

1800



1650

Tokugawa Japan
era brings sex
into new qualities
of objects and
actions



1873

U.S. Congress passes
Comstock Act making
contraceptives illegal

1890

1889

Krafft-Ebing coins
term *heterosexuality*

1869

Kertbeny coins the
term *homosexuality*



1905

Sigmund Freud
introduces notion
of childhood
sexuality in
*Three Essays on
the Theory of
Sexuality*

1920s

First wave of
feminism in the
United States



1920



1916

Margaret Sanger
fights Comstock
Law and coins
term *birth control*

1942
Planned
Parenthood
Federation of
America
founded



1948
Alfred Kinsey
publishes
*Sexual Behavior
and the Human Male*

1950

1948
United Nations
Charter on
Human Rights
invokes new era
of sexual and
gender global
rights

1953
First issue of
Playboy published

1960



1960
Second wave
of feminism
movement



1962
First birth
control pill

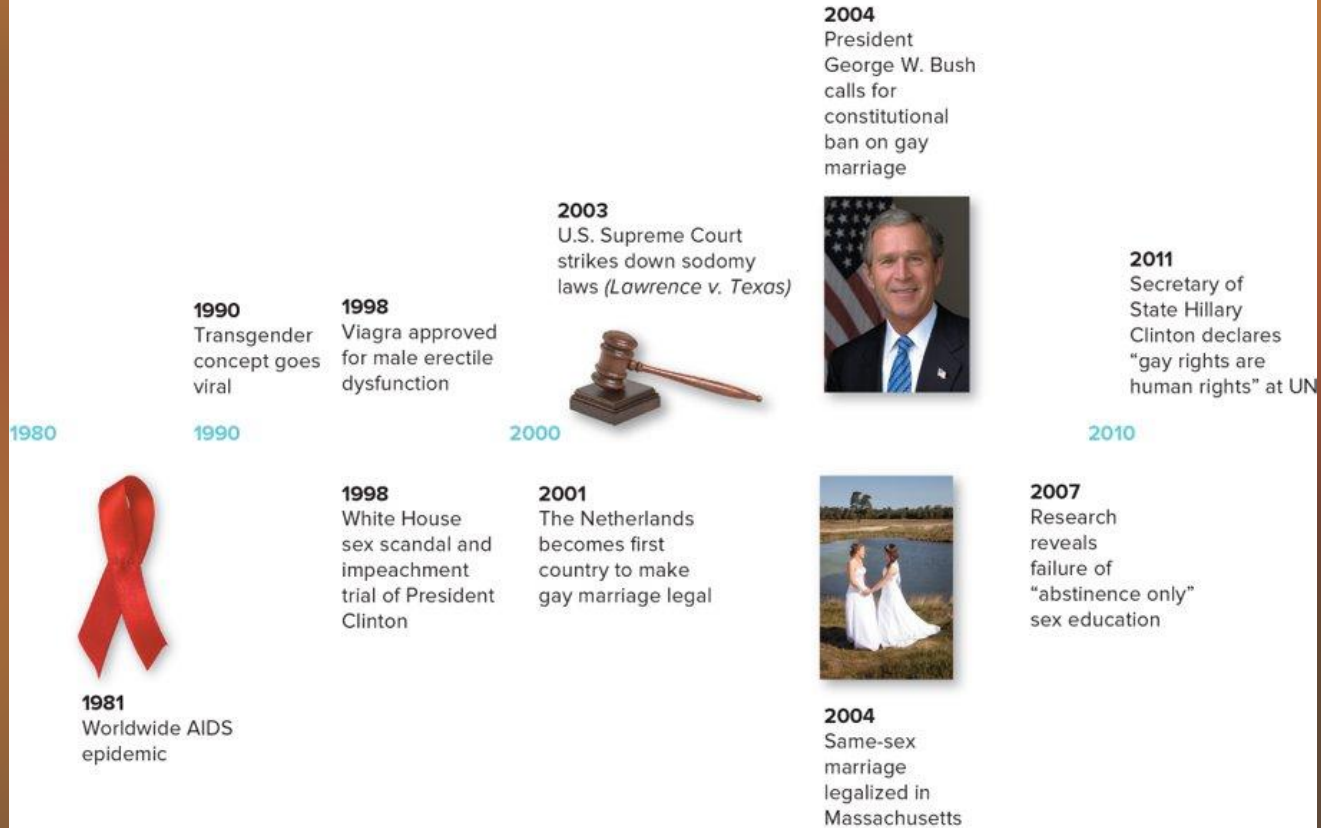
1965
Supreme Court
strikes down
Comstock Act,
making contraceptive
information legal
in the United States

1969
Stonewall riots
(New York) and
LGBT movement
founded

1970

1973
American Psychiatric
Association declares
homosexuality normal

1973
Roe v. Wade
legalizes abortion
in the United States



A Brief History of Sex and Civilization

- Sexuality and religion have always been and will continue to be connected.
- Civilization is shaped by **sexual culture**—the shared distinct sexual meanings and sexual practices of a group.
- Diverse forms of sexuality are linked to the **great world religions** — Hinduism, Judaism, Buddhism, Christianity, and Islam.
 - These religions are global, have many followers, are rooted in traditional texts and moral principles, and have shaped history

Asian Civilization

Complex sexual cultures: fertility, pleasure, and procreation through marriage.

- Hinduism spread from India and South Asia.
- In India, female fertility and mutual sexual satisfaction hold importance
- Buddhism promoted tolerance for diverse sexual expression.
- Spread to China, Korea, and Japan.

Ancient Greece, Rome, and Christianity

Complex sexuality and love: pleasure + restraint

- Democratic sexual culture, limited the role of women in public
- Gods viewed as highly sexual.
- Accepted same-sex relationships
- Roman Empire kept Greek traditions at first
- Decline of Rome led to outlawing same-sex relationships and slave/prostitutes sex

Ancient Greece, Rome, and Christianity

Emergence of Christianity reduced freedom of sexual expression in the Roman Empire.

Early Christianity strongly influenced Western civilization, marriage, and sexual practice.

Roman Catholic Church introduced sex-negative ideas

- Focused on sin and the dangers of the female bod

Islamic Civilization

Islam spread throughout the Middle East

Central values: marriage, family, Heaven, and sexual virtue.

- Muslims upheld male sexual honor, female virginity before marriage, gender segregation, and children's sexual purity
- Unlike the Christian West, Islam emphasized a husband's duty to sexually pleasure his wife

Western Europe from the Crusades to the 19th Century

Christianity and Islam became major influences; Christianity organized religious crusades.

- **Chivalry** — a code of Christian knights that focused on purity of heart and body, chastity for females, and honor in war.

Christianity became a state institution.

- Religion controlled women and sexuality
- Inquisition enforced penalties for sodomy and Church violations
- Fear of the devil suppressed childhood sexuality, promiscuity, and homosexuality.

Western Europe from the Crusades to the 19th Century

- The Renaissance brought new art and scientific discoveries that challenged the Church.
- During the Enlightenment, reason and science were applied to nature, society, art, government, and sexuality.
- Sexual expression and sexual diversity began to flourish.
- Modern public health systems emerged in the 19th century.

The Victorian Era and Sexual Identity

- Sex was considered private and never discussed.
- Rigid gender roles.
 - Women — submissive, motherly, asexual
 - Children — pure and sexually innocent
 - Men — sexually aggressive, conflicted between good and evil
 - Doctors and psychiatrists treated conflicted sexual motives

The Victorian Era and Sexual Identity

19th century: new sexual expressions, positive and negative

- **Sexual identity** — self-identification as heterosexual, bisexual, or homosexual.

A new norm, heterosexual couple, a long-term romantic sexual partnership.

20th-Century Sexuality

Companionate marriage — the cultural idea that a man and woman are not just sex partners but also social and intellectual companions and equals for life.

- Ideal expanded across social classes, ethnic groups, and to gay and lesbian couples.
- Religious remained highly influential.

World wars brought major societal changes.

- Women worked in factories and management
- Post-WWII — early contraceptives and more STIs

20th-Century Sexuality

1960s — second-wave of feminism

- Contraceptives widely available; recreational sex increased
- Greater variation in sexual behavior

1970s — gay liberation gained momentum

1981 — AIDS epidemic begins

- Religious conservatism campaigns against homosexuality, abortion, and sex education

1990s — sexual literacy emerged; recognition of sexuality as a human right

Sexual Norms and Sexual Socialization

Sexual norm — a cultural standard of sexual behavior expected of people in a particular role, relationship, and situation.

Sexual socialization — the application of a culture's blueprints to sexual feelings, thoughts, and behaviors.

Sexual Norms and Sexual Socialization

Cultural relativism — the viewing of people's attitudes and behavior in the context of their own culture.

Cultural chauvinism — the belief that one's cultural norms are superior to the norms of another's group.

Sexual chauvinism — the belief that one's sexual culture is superior to others.

Sexual Unlearning

Sexual unlearning — the process of unlearning something about sexuality that may have been learned at a very young age.

Sexuality and the Great World Religions

- Understanding how religious beliefs influence holistic sexuality is key to sexual well-being
- Many religions traditionally focus on negative sexual attitudes

Sex, Religion, and Reality

Sexual beliefs vary by belief in one god versus many gods

Polytheism — belief in multiple gods and spirits.

- Hinduism and Buddhism are generally seen as polytheistic, and both are generally more sex-approving.

Monotheism — belief in one God.

- Christianity, Judaism, and Islam are monotheistic.

Sex, Religion, and Reality

Organized religion — sharing practices of worship with others and belonging to a group that is based on shared beliefs and practices.

Religious identity — social expression of an individual's faith in the context of community and nation.

- Can influence whether a person follows sexual taboos or beliefs.
- Sexual behavior shapes personal and civic identity

Sex, Religion, and Reality

TOPIC	HINDUISM	BUDDHISM	JUDAISM	ISLAM	CHRISTIANITY
SEX	Not openly discussed; pleasure is valued, with restraint	Positively viewed, in moderation; mutual pleasure between spouses	Joyful; for procreation; masturbation condemned	Taboo topic; mutual pleasure between spouses	Supported in marriage to some extent; masturbation sinful in some groups and tolerated in others
PREMARITAL SEX	Disapproved of, and virginity expected for marriage	Disapproved	Disapproved	Disapproved, and virginity is prized	Disapproved of in many groups; a sin in Catholicism and some Protestant groups
DIVORCE	Disapproved, and may stigmatize divorced women	Not prohibited; viewed as causing pain	Negatively viewed; allowed in certain situations	Allowed under extreme conditions	Disapproved of but tolerated in most groups, with some exceptions
HOMOSEXUALITY	Tabooed topic; behavior known of in Indian history	Not tabooed but not encouraged	Forbidden; some Jews are more open to it than in the past	Condemned	Treated differently among all groups

Sex, Religion, and Reality

TOPIC	HINDUISM	BUDDHISM	JUDAISM	ISLAM	CHRISTIANITY
ADULTERY	Double standard: women tolerate to save marriages; men may have a mistress	Avoid because it causes disharmony	Forbidden	Forbidden; the Koran allows men to have four wives	Forbidden
CONTRACEPTION	Accepted but not widely used	Accepted	More accepted now than in traditional Judaism	Negatively viewed	Many groups allow it; some do not
ABORTION	Not accepted, though attitude about it may be changing	Not accepted; it disrupts harmony and causes guilt	Mandatory when the mother's life is in jeopardy	Not accepted	Generally not accepted; a sin in Catholicism

Spirituality and Sexual Behavior in the United States

Christianity shaped U.S. sexual attitudes since the Puritans

Puritanism — the morally upright and socially strict beliefs and practices of the Puritans.

- Influenced discussions on nudity, premarital/extramarital sex, virginity, and pornography

Questions?

